



Packaging waste

EU rules on packaging and packaging waste, including design and waste management.

[Overview](#)

[Background](#)

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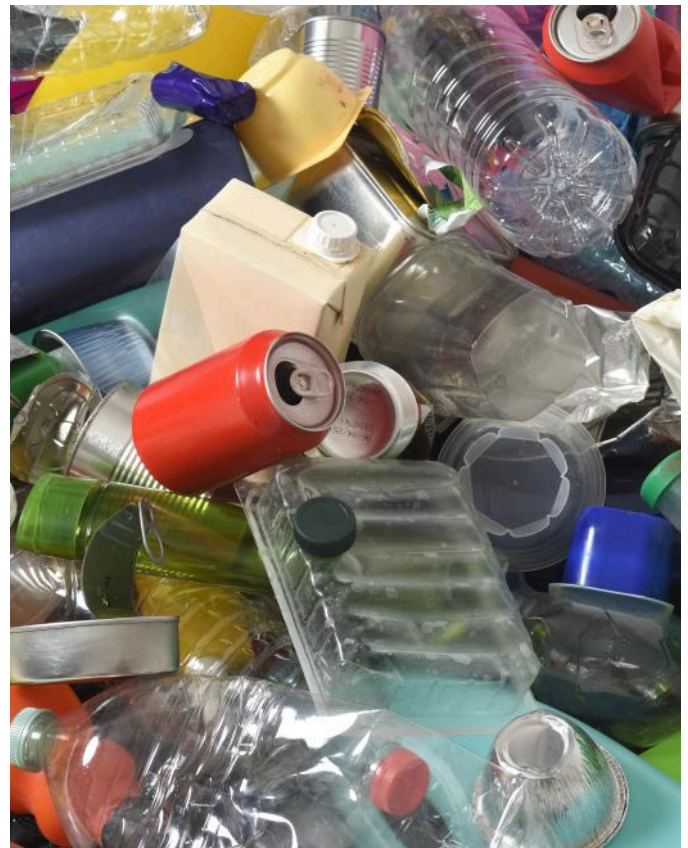
Overview

Packaging uses large quantities of primary raw materials. Increasing quantities of packaging are generated in the EU while the levels of re-use, collection and recycling remain low.

This is a significant barrier to achieving a low-carbon, circular and resilient economy.

EU rules on packaging cover all packaging and packaging waste, regardless of material or origin.

They also set requirements for manufacturing, composition, and the reusable or recoverable nature of all packaging placed on the EU market and include packaging waste management and prevention measures.



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Legislation: [Regulation \(EU\) 2025/40 on packaging and packaging waste](#)

Status: In force since 11 February 2025

Application date: 12 August 2026

[Summary of legislation](#) + [factsheet](#) + [packaging and packaging waste explained](#)



40%

of plastics used
in the EU are in
packaging



1/2

of marine litter is
from packaging



186.5 kg

of waste
generated in the
EU per person
in 2022

Objectives and aims

The rules aim to minimise the quantities of packaging and waste generated while lowering the use of primary raw materials and fostering the transition to a circular, sustainable and competitive economy.

The Regulation aims to:-

- Make all packaging on the EU market **recyclable in an economically viable way by 2030**.
- **Safely increase** the use of recycled plastics in packaging.
- **Decrease the use of virgin materials** in packaging and put the sector on track to **climate neutrality by 2050**.
- **Improve recycling** and the functioning of the Single Market by creating a harmonised set of rules that apply in all Member States.

What's included in the law?

The PPWR establishes a new set of requirements in line with Europe's waste rules that cover the entire packaging life cycle – from product design to waste handling, including:

- **Restrictions on certain single-use plastics**, such as for individual portions or sachets of condiments and sauces.
- A requirement for take-away businesses to offer customers the **option to bring their own containers** at no extra cost.
- Minimising **substances of concern**, including restrictions on **PFAS** in food contact packaging if they exceed certain thresholds.

The PPWR was preceded by the [Packaging and Packaging Waste Directive 94/62/EC \(PPWD\)](#), which was generally repealed on **12 August 2026**. However, some provisions of the existing regulation will continue to apply even after that date.

To minimise administrative burdens and costs for small businesses, the Commission proposed, in December 2025, in its so-called [Environmental Omnibus](#), **to suspend the obligation for producers to appoint an authorised representative** when they sell packaged products directly to consumers in Member States other than the one where they are located. The proposal is currently being examined by the European Parliament and the Council of the European Union.

Related laws

Marking and identification

- [Decision establishing the identification system for packaging materials](#)

Data and Reporting

- [Directive standardising and rationalising reports on the implementation of certain Directives relating to the environment](#)
- [Decision concerning questionnaires for Member States' reports on the implementation of certain Directives in the waste sector](#)
- [Decision establishing the formats relating to the database system and implementing decision amending this decision](#)
- [Implementing decision laying down the methodology for the calculation of the annual consumption of lightweight plastic carrier bags](#)

Derogations

- [Decision exempting certain economic operators that use pallet wrappings and straps from the 100% reuse requirements of these packaging formats](#)
- [Decision establishing the conditions for a derogation for plastic crates and plastic pallets in relation to the heavy metal concentration levels](#)
- [Decision establishing the conditions for a derogation for glass packaging in relation to the heavy metal concentration levels](#)

Notification of draft measures Member States intend to implement within the framework of the Packaging Directive

- [Directive laying down a procedure for providing information in the field of technical regulations and rules on Information Society services](#)

Publications

- [Scoping study to assess the feasibility of further EU measures on waste prevention and implementation of the Plastic Bags Directive. Part II, Implementation of Plastic Bags Directive](#)
- [Report on the effectiveness of the essential requirements for packaging and packaging waste and proposals for reinforcement](#)
- [Report on the relevance of biodegradable and compostable consumer plastic products and packaging in a circular economy](#)
- [Report on the impact of the use of "oxo-degradable" plastic on the environment](#)

Learn more about packaging waste and waste management at the [Environmental Data Centre on Waste](#) and the [European Environmental Agency](#).

Implementation

Support and resources for Member States, businesses and other stakeholders to help them understand and comply with the rules is available:

- [Information on the implementation of the Packaging and Packaging Waste Regulation, including details of national competent authorities](#)
- [Commission Delegated Decision applying to the use of pallet wrappings and straps in packaging](#)
- [Guidelines on the implementation of the Regulation for economic actors and Member States](#)
(March 2026)
- [Frequently Asked Questions](#) (August 2026)

Contact

For questions about EU environmental policy, please contact [Europe Direct](#).

News



News article | 30 June 2026

Commission clarifies rules on plastic bottles recycling

The measures will ensure transparency in calculating recycled content in new single-use polyethylene terephthalate (PET) bottles.

🕒 1 min read



News article | 29 April 2026

Commission proposes change to waste shipment rules

Under current EU rules, the export of mixed municipal waste for recovery to non-EEA countries, such as Switzerland, will soon be banned.

🕒 2 min read



News article | 16 April 2026

Ten EU countries exceeding SUPD collection targets

The Commission published its first report under the Single-Use Plastics Directive (SUPD), showing Member States' progress.

🕒 3 min read

[See all news on Plastics →](#)